

Crash Course

This time the Digit Diary takes you through crashes—avoidable car crashes and, thanks to Nimda, unavoidable PC crashes

Four to five comparison tests every month, which means on an average, testing some 60 products, plus the standalone tests for new hardware and software products...and that's only for Digit. On any given day, the Digital Media Research and Test Centre looks like a hardware shack with gadgets and techies lined up all over the place, talking in nothing else but gobbledgeek. At least that's what it sounds like

to lesser mortals, more technology, less English.

At the end of one such day, with the usual quota of benchmarking products and solving sundry technology-related problems for readers and colleagues alike, Hatim Kantawalla, our deputy head of the Test Centre, was driving back home. Having spent the previous night in the office to put the final touches on the Digit Smart Buyer's guide, he was feeling somewhat less than his usual exuberant self.

While waiting for a signal to turn green, Hatim was mulling over all the things that needed to be done the next day. Thus preoccupied, he momentarily relaxed his foot on the brake pedal. Disaster, which usually doesn't need more than a minute to strike, promptly did.

The car slid forward and clipped the rear of a Sumo in front. Ironically this was the office Sumo, which was loaded with people who travel from our office in Nerul to Bandra/Andheri every day.

The champ at games, with reflexes honed by years of Quake, quickly applied the brakes and shifted into reverse. As luck would have it, he had an auto driver waiting behind him with other plans. The auto driver thought the signal had turned green and raced ahead. The result: the auto and the car collided too.

Hatim, by now thoroughly confused, gave the all's well sign to his concerned colleagues in the

Sumo, pulled over by the kerb, and got out to examine the damage, if any. While he was berating the auto driver, he heard a commotion with several panic-stricken voices calling out his name. He looked up and saw his car sliding forward, heading straight for a tree! In a flash Hatim, thinking of what might happen to him if he has one more accident, got in the car and averted another minor disaster.

The aftermath: A sheepish deputy head of the Test Centre, avid follower of the formula one racing circuits, was subjected to doses of sarcastic wit, much to the glee of other test centre geeks. No, he hasn't given up driving. Not yet. ■



Illustration: Mahesh Benkar

All in a day's work

You know the rest. In the books you have read
How the British Regulars fired and fled,
How the farmers gave them ball for ball,
From behind each fence and farmyard wall,
Chasing the redcoats down the lane,
Then crossing the fields to emerge again,
Under the trees at the turn of the road,
And only pausing to fire and load.

Some of you may be familiar with this poem by H. W. Longfellow. Well, we had an experience that made this poem very relevant.

Issue closing time tends to get quite exciting at Digit every month. But sometimes there is that little 'extra'. This time people were bustling about as usual, checking layouts, proofing the stories and so on, when the peace was disturbed by a sudden commotion. It was Karan charging down the aisle shouting for everyone to not open any of the .eml files that

may be present on their machine.

Why? "Because it's a virus...the Nimda virus".

This was the first warning that most of us had about the outbreak of the Nimda virus. This was naturally followed by groans (and colourful curses) from a few people who had unwittingly opened these files. Then came 'qualified advice' from the quacks around which involved applying a bunch of patches and scrambling for the latest bunch of anti virus updates.

Coinciding as it did with the closing of this issue, the outbreak of the virus created its own set of complications. Nimda spreads by infecting shared folders over the network and since we frequently need to share files, you can imagine the panic this created.

But there's an old saying that nothing can get Digsters down for long. A solution was found quickly, guns reloaded, so to speak, and work was back to normal in no time at all.